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Cinema and poetry are the same thing, Prévert said. Not always, alas. But it's surely true here.

Derek Malcolm
The Guardian, 1999

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men are content, but, as the movie progresses, her hold over each of them changes their lives.

Ultimate disappointment

In the movie's second half, the suitors' dissatisfaction breeds resentment. Frédérick achieves his dream of playing Othello since at last he understands the pain of jealousy. For Lacenaire, the story

ends in tragedy as he dies on the scaffold for killing de Montray. For Garance, too, there is no happy resolution: the man she finally sets her heart upon – Baptiste – is ultimately out of her reach.

Much of this drama unfolds before the eyes of the “children of paradise,” the working-class audience in the cheap seats. They are the most boisterous characters in the story—like the cinema audience, furthest from the stage yet also the most demanding. The paradise crowd cries out for entertainment. They are eager to see suffering and pain. As Baptiste's father says, “A kick in the rear, if well delivered, is a sure laugh.” They want novelty, too. But “novelty,” he says, “is as old as the hills.” ■

Baptiste's father plays for laughs from the “children of paradise,” even as Baptiste reinvents the role of Pierrot as a childlike, disappointed lover, whose pain tugs at the audience's heartstrings.



Marcel Carné Director

Born in Paris in 1906, Marcel Carné began his movie career as a critic, while working in his spare time as a cameraman on silent movies. By 1931, he was directing his own short movies. In 1936, Carné teamed up with surrealist poet Jacques Prévert for the first time on the movie *Jenny*. Over the next decade, the pair made a series of “poetic realist” movies, casting a fatalistic eye over the lives of characters on the margins of society, which established Carné as a star in French cinema.

In the 1950s, Carné's reputation was eclipsed as the younger generation of the French New Wave demanded a less artificial style. However, he remained in high regard among his fellow directors, and François Truffaut once said that he “would give up all my movies to have directed *Children of Paradise*.” Carné continued to make movies into the 1970s. He died in 1996.

Key movies

1938 *Hôtel du Nord*
 1942 *Night Visitors*
 1945 *Children of Paradise*
 1946 *Gates of the Night*

